

Chapter 156 - Companionship

Ning Fuyi had no time to push the person away when the spicy wine flowed into her throat, along with the other's soft tongue tip that licked her tongue briefly before quickly withdrawing.

It was so quick it seemed like an illusion, but after the spicy taste faded from her mouth, the warm sensation on her tongue made Ning Fuyi's entire body heat up. Even the most solid ice couldn't dispel this kind of heat.

Not to mention the body in her arms - it looked slender, but when sitting on her legs, it was heavy with substantial weight.

She must truly be mad. Chu Qingqiu didn't dare look at the expression on Ning Fuyi's face, only staring at the wine cup in her hands to ease the stiffness in her body.

Fortunately, Ning Fuyi had already dismissed everyone, leaving only the two of them in the entire hall.

"Are you no longer angry?" Chu Qingqiu spoke again.

"Your offense is forgiven." Ning Fuyi could no longer bear the burning heat throughout her body, so she exerted force and pushed the woman off her knees.

Chu Qingqiu's legs were already weak, and being suddenly pushed off, she hurriedly supported herself against a screen to steady herself.

She had lived for ten thousand years, and this was the first time in her life she had lowered herself to seduce someone, yet that person not only didn't appreciate it but showed no mercy at all.

So the Divine Venerable who had lived for ten thousand years crushed the porcelain screen in her palm, her devastatingly beautiful face flushing red with anger.

Ning Fuyi knew nothing of this. She just pretended to cough and casually picked up a wine cup. Remembering that the woman had used it, her heartstring inexplicably jumped again, so she put the wine cup down.

"Someone come." She waved toward the back, and a beauty stepped forward with lotus steps to replace her cup.

"I didn't ask you to follow me. Why did you come?" Ning Fuyi sipped some clear wine. Her earlier mood for listening to music and enjoying pleasures had completely disappeared, but she couldn't generate any real anger.

Chu Qingqiu's gaze hadn't moved from the replaced cup. She threw away the porcelain fragments crushed in her palm and said lightly: "Jiuying¹ told me to serve you. Shouldn't I follow?"

"Fine, considering your loyalty." Ning Fuyi said no more, draining the cup in one gulp. She rose with hands behind her back, her body passing through the wall to emerge into the noisy long street outside.

Her figure was graceful as she moved through the demons and monsters. The demon race coming here seemed already accustomed to the Demon Lord's behavior - they were respectful when they saw her but not surprised.

Chu Qingqiu carried White Bone², following her at a distance, silently trailing her for half an hour before realizing that the woman ahead was just walking with no particular destination.

Ning Fuyi occasionally stopped at some stalls, reaching out to touch those horrifying things, but more often she wandered aimlessly, as if nothing could make her stay, nothing could allow her to stay.

Though her tall, slender silhouette was clearly visible, in Chu Qingqiu's eyes it seemed so lonely - no past, no future, not even a present.

If she herself without all those experiences would be Su Mo³, then who would Ning Fuyi be without having lived through two lifetimes?

The now-calm Chu Qingqiu suddenly felt heartache, needle-fine and dense.

Thinking about it now, her Yiyi⁴ who was always full of sincere devotion had never really received much affection either.

Ning Fuyi crouched down in front of a food stall. Outside the door, an iron cage contained many spirit beast cubs. Her slender fingers stroked the cage door, her phoenix eyes faintly showing curiosity.

"Demon Lord." The butcher shop owner hurriedly crawled out from the blood-reeking door. He had no hands or feet - everything below his head was a snake body. He smiled obsequiously: "This shop kills fresh and stews immediately. These are freshly caught spirit beasts, very tender meat!"

"Want one?" The shopkeeper looked hopeful and casually grabbed a white puppy, about to wring its throat.

The white puppy suddenly let out a miserable cry, as if tearing through some barrier. Ning Fuyi, who had seemed relatively mild just moments before, suddenly flew into a rage. Demonic energy overflowed around her body, and in the blink of an eye she pressed against the shopkeeper's vital spot, pinning him to the ground while letting out a terrifying low growl from her throat. This scared the shopkeeper so much that his tail coiled into several loops as he repeatedly begged for mercy.

Ning Fuyi's sudden outburst frightened all the surrounding demons into fleeing in panic. Chu Qingqiu, hidden in the crowd, quickly drew out white silk to protect the small white dog while also wrapping it around the woman's waist, forcibly pulling her away.

Ning Fuyi's feet left the ground, then she angrily shattered the white silk and pointed her sword at Chu Qingqiu: "It's you again! This lord is a demon - do you really think this lord won't kill people?"

"Then kill me." Chu Qingqiu didn't channel her power again but simply spoke.

After saying this, she even moved her chest closer to Ning Fuyi's blade. The butcher shop owner who had narrowly escaped death hurriedly crawled back inside his door, leaving the iron cage overturned with the spirit beast cubs chattering and scattering.

She was certain Ning Fuyi wouldn't strike, and indeed Ning Fuyi didn't. Her fingertips gripping the sword hilt turned white, then she sheathed the sword and turned to leave without a word.

Chu Qingqiu pressed her lips together, bent down to pick up the small white dog that hadn't fled, placed it in her arms, and once again silently followed.

This time Ning Fuyi walked out of the demon market, following the uneven stone roads of the Demon Realm, through swamps full of man-eating butterflies, toward a valley sheltered from the wind.

"Stop following me." She stopped in the swamp, waving her hand to disperse a cloud of butterflies. Those butterfly wings each had a pair of bright yellow eyes that would close when they flew.

"Get lost, do you hear me?" She turned around, her eyes gloomy, her palms gathering crackling lightning.

"You're very afraid." Chu Qingqiu didn't dodge or block but spoke calmly.

"This lord is the Demon Lord! What would this lord fear?" Ning Fuyi seemed to have heard the greatest joke, her palm discharging lightning that splashed up mud and water. "What right do you have to speculate?"

The muddy water soaked Chu Qingqiu's skirt hem and splattered on her skin, but she didn't dodge. Those perceptive peach blossom eyes stayed open as she stepped forward.

"You don't know who you are, don't trust what others say, and don't dare trust anyone, so you're afraid - afraid people will discover your timidity, afraid they'll discover you don't dare kill, discover you're not a demon." She said.

"You can't bear to see even a dog die, yet you pretend to be violent and bloodthirsty." Chu Qingqiu took another step forward.

Ning Fuyi's straight shoulders trembled slightly. She stared fixedly at Chu Qingqiu, finally saying coldly: "Get lost."

"I hit the mark." Chu Qingqiu endured the slight pain in her heart and continued.

"I told you to get lost!" Ning Fuyi's eyes were already reddened, not knowing where to turn. The nightmares that had plagued her for months echoed in her heart - in those dreams she was constantly devoured by countless black shadows, and when she opened her eyes, every person looked like the evil spirits that consumed her in dreams.

A gale kicked up mud and sand, and lightning surged toward the woman. Chu Qingqiu quickly waved her hand to block it, her feet creating a half-person-high trench where the lightning struck.

Ning Fuyi looked at her from across the trench, her eyebrows sharp. After watching for a while, she suddenly turned and left, her black robe swaying from her shoulders as she quickly departed.

Chu Qingqiu exhaled, her palm covering her chest, her eyes softening. Around her, only countless butterflies remained.

Half an hour later, Chu Qingqiu returned to the demon cavern, retracing her path back to the demon palace. At the palace entrance stood a woman - Han Ya⁵, holding a warming stove and pacing worriedly.

"Divine Venerable." She bowed her head in greeting.

"Is she inside? Why don't you go in?" Chu Qingqiu looked at the tightly closed great doors and spoke.

"This subordinate dares not." Han Ya looked troubled. "The Demon Lord never allows anyone to enter the palace when she rests. Even approaching would enrage her. Only Lord Qilin⁶ can get close sometimes, but doesn't dare stay long."

"This subordinate can sense that she's guarding against something. Besides demon race, she especially fears immortal race, which is precisely why we initially didn't dare invite the Divine Venerable into the Demon Realm."

Chu Qingqiu's eyes flickered, then she said she understood and took the warming stove from Han Ya: "I'll go in and look. You may go."

Watching Han Ya leave with repeated warnings and instructions, Chu Qingqiu steadied her mind before pushing open the door with a creak and walking into the palace.

In the cold, quiet palace with dim lighting, there was a black shadow in the darkest corner, curled up in a corner.

Chu Qingqiu silently walked over and crouched in front of the black shadow. Seeing that the figure didn't object, she reached out and quickly felt moisture.

This wetness made her eyes soften too. She rubbed left and right to wipe away those tears, then stuffed the warming stove into her arms, letting those cold hands hold it.

"Didn't you tell me to get lost?" A voice mixed with nasal congestion sounded. Ning Fuyi turned her face toward the side without Chu Qingqiu.

"I'm your attendant. Where could I go?" Chu Qingqiu quickly accepted her new identity, then accompanied her in crouching for a long time, taking out a ball of white, living thing from her arms and placing it beside her hand.

"Why did you bring this dirty thing back?" Ning Fuyi muttered, her hand stroking the small white dog's head. The little dog had already fallen asleep in Chu Qingqiu's arms and was now sleeping sweetly.

"You used to have a small white dog too." Chu Qingqiu said softly. "But it was very fat."

"Nonsense." Ning Fuyi scoffed.

Chu Qingqiu didn't force her to believe, instead rising to tidy the arhat bed⁷ that she had messed up while sleeping, asking: "Want to rest?"

Ning Fuyi shook her head.

"Nightmares?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

Ning Fuyi sharply raised her head, examining her in the darkness, then said: "How do you know?"

"I see your brow area is dark - it seems you have nightmares daily to have such an appearance." Chu Qingqiu reached out to smooth the soft pillow. "Come, I'll ensure you sleep peacefully tonight."

The woman's voice was calm with little inflection, inexplicably trustworthy. Ning Fuyi hesitated, then finally stood up, sat on the bed edge and rolled over, quickly removing all her accessories before curling up against the wall and closing her eyes.

Chu Qingqiu initially wanted to laugh at her posture but didn't, because the Ning Fuyi who used to be in front of her wouldn't act this way.

She had endured countless hardships but was rarely vulnerable.

Now with all memories lost, what remained was the deepest, most indelible fear in her soul.

If she had been kinder to her in the previous life, would she not be so afraid now? Regret suddenly swept over her, and Chu Qingqiu closed her eyes.

She didn't know how the girl who used to cry so much later shouldered all suffering and pain, tempering herself into a strong-hearted demon.

Chu Qingqiu didn't know.

The initially fierce desire for her to recover her memories now faded. Being able to accompany her daily was already very good.

She raised her hand, and some imperceptible pollen fell from above the bed, illuminated by candlelight into faintly glowing traces. A light fragrance soon enveloped the surroundings, then Chu Qingqiu turned over onto the bed, pillowing on the other side of the soft pillow.

Ning Fuyi stiffened for a moment, turning to drive her off the bed, but heard the woman say in an extremely serious tone: "Do you still want to rest properly or not?"

Ning Fuyi thought about it, so she didn't push her away. She just stared blankly for a moment before curling up again. The faint floral fragrance flowed through her nose into her entire body, and her limbs quickly grew weary.

This woman was truly useful, Ning Fuyi thought to herself.

As she drowsily began to fall asleep, a soft white arm reached from the outside, passing through her arm to embrace her waist, then with force, Ning Fuyi moved backward uncontrollably, then her entire body was wrapped in warm, soft embrace.

What status did this person have to dare embrace her, the dignified Demon Lord like this? Ning Fuyi wanted to get angry, but the floral fragrance was too pleasant. She only opened her mouth but made no sound.

Looking down, she saw arms like trimmed branches with faintly protruding joints, some blue blood vessels faintly visible under the thin skin.

The place against her back was like a cloud. Ning Fuyi didn't dare move as a blush crept up her cheeks.

"Don't be afraid." Chu Qingqiu gently patted Ning Fuyi, her gaze falling on the trembling shoulders before her, speaking softly.

"Little White will protect you."

Footnotes:

¹ **Jiuying (九婴)** - Character name referring to a nine-headed mythical beast.

² **White Bone (白骨)** - Chu Qingqiu's divine weapon.

³ **Su Mo (苏陌)** - A character from earlier in the story, representing what Chu Qingqiu might have been without her experiences.

⁴ **Yiyi (衣衣)** - Nickname for Ning Fuyi.

⁵ **Han Ya (寒鸦)** - Character name meaning "cold crow."

⁶ **Lord Qilin (麒麟大人)** - Refers to Jiuying in her qilin form.

⁷ **Arhat bed (罗汉床)** - A traditional Chinese daybed/couch.